

Phishing Awareness: Protecting Yourself and Your Company

What is phishing?

Phishing is a type of cyber attack where criminals pretend to be a trusted person or organization to trick you into revealing passwords, clicking malicious links, or sending money. According to industry reports, over 90% of successful cyber attacks start with a phishing email, and the average cost of a data breach reached 4.4 million US dollars in 2025.

Common types of phishing

1. Email phishing: mass emails that imitate banks, delivery services, or internal IT teams.
2. Spear phishing: targeted messages that use your name, role, or recent projects to look convincing.
3. Smishing and vishing: phishing via SMS text messages or phone calls.
4. CEO fraud: attackers impersonate an executive and urgently request a wire transfer or gift cards.

Red flags to watch for

- A sense of urgency or threats ("Your account will be closed in 24 hours").
- Sender addresses that almost match a real domain, such as hrm-labs.co instead of hrmlabs.com.
- Unexpected attachments or links, especially .zip, .html, or macro-enabled documents.
- Requests for passwords, one-time codes, or payment details. IT will never ask for your password.
- Generic greetings, spelling mistakes, and a tone that does not match the supposed sender.

How to check a link safely

Hover over a link before clicking to see the real destination. On mobile, press and hold the link. If the domain looks unfamiliar, do not open it. Type the address of the official website yourself instead.

What to do if you receive a suspicious message

1. Do not click links, open attachments, or reply.
2. Verify the request through a different channel, for example by calling the person using a known number.
3. Report the message to the IT security team using the Report Phishing button.
4. Delete the message after reporting it.

What to do if you already clicked

Act fast. Disconnect from the network if a file was downloaded, change your password immediately from a trusted device, and contact IT security. Reporting within the first hour can reduce damage significantly. You will not be punished for reporting a mistake; hiding it is what causes real harm.

Best practices

- Enable multi-factor authentication (MFA) on every account. MFA blocks more than 99% of automated account attacks.
- Use a password manager and a unique password for each service.
- Keep your devices and apps updated.
- Think before you share information about your job on social media.

Remember: stop, look, and verify. When in doubt, report it.